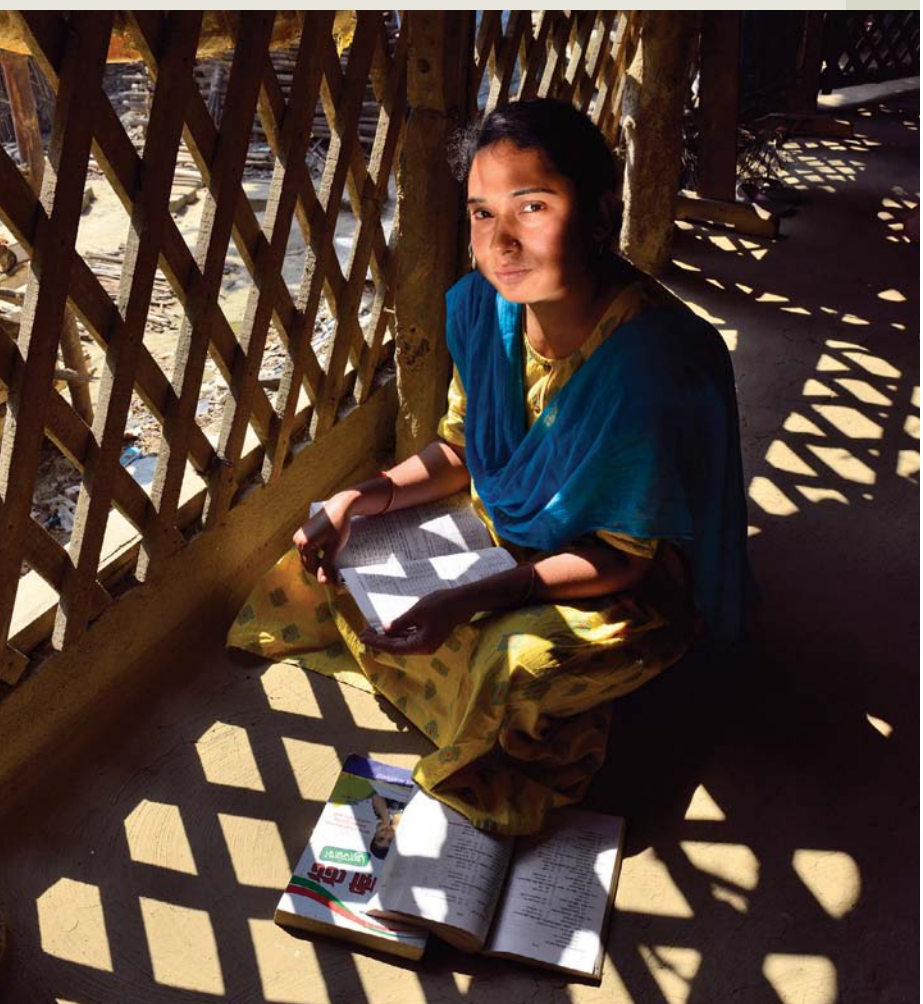
**WEST BENGAL: Jinat Asrin, 32, *B.A. in Bangla literature***

**Job applied for: Secondary/ higher secondary teacher**
**Total vacancies: 17,400; Total applications: 300,000**

Jinat is among the droves protesting the delay in recruitment of school teachers in Bengal. The West Midnapore native, who's married to a jobless PhD holder, has been waiting to land a secondary/higher secondary teacher's job since 2016. One of 300,000 applicants for 17,400 vacancies, she never got a call, despite being on the merit list. Finally, in her second month of pregnancy, she joined the protests and suffered a miscarriage. Back at the demonstration site after having lost everything, she says: "I have nothing to fear anymore. My father is 65 and has suffered a stroke. I take tuitions to run my family." The exam to select upper primary teachers, too, is in a mess— 14,339 vacancies, 228,220 successful candidates, 28,900 interviews... and 2,032 court cases! The Calcutta High Court finally scrapped the process and asked the School Service Commission to redo things. The alleged irregularities are of an unbelievable nature. Candidates without even pass marks, and certainly not in any list, have made it to counselling. And deserving candidates like Jinat are languishing despite being empanelled.



SUBIR HALDER

secretariat assistants.

In Rajasthan, a test to recruit schoolteachers saw a question paper leak in September 2021! One of two papers stood cancelled. So did the dreams of 1.6 million applicants competing for 15,000 posts. Similar allegations, in a 2016 exam conducted by the West Bengal School Service Commission to select Upper Primary Teachers (V to VIII), have kept the fate of 28,900 candidates hanging. "A disproportionately high number of candidates apply for a few posts. Ministries are not equipped to conduct exams of such massive scale. There's also political interference and the lure of easy money. So such incidents take place," says Kumar Sanjay Krishna, former chief secretary, Assam.

## What's the way forward?

Experts concur that the government has very limited scope to enhance its recruiting potential and, therefore, has to think out of the box to do what it can. Former DoPT secretary Shantanu Consul says governments must overhaul organisational structures. "When the government gets, say, India Post to shed flab, it gives them a chance to bolster strength in education and health," he says. Mehrotra, too, says that unproductive manpower must be trimmed to create openings where it's urgently needed—education, health and police. N.K. Choudhary, former HoD, Economics, Patna University, says investment in health and education automatically creates future opportunities. Insiders say governments have indeed been innovating. For instance, Bengal recently opened up internships for honours graduates securing first class. "About 6,000 such students will be appointed as trainees and paid a stipend of Rs 5,000 a month," says a labour department secretary, requesting anonymity.

All agree on the need to streamline and clean up the whole process. "If India can organise elections on such a massive scale, why can't we do the same with exams? All exams can be concluded in a maximum of nine months," says Anupam. In August 2020, the Modi cabinet sought to address this issue by setting up a National Recruitment Agency (NRA) to conduct a common preliminary exam for central jobs: a winning candidate can apply to UPSC et al with the common eligibility test (CET) score that exam